

"Our tragic age demands poetry of courage and not
whimpers about the inevitable end of all *maya*."

FREE RADICAL

His work kick-started the phenomenon of the Empire writing back. The lifelong polemicist remained engaged with society and supported wide-ranging experimentation in the arts.

■ By Snehal Shingavi

In the final pages of Mulk Raj Anand's most famous novel, *Untouchable*, a poet describes the essential character of Indians that would allow them to succeed where the British had failed: "We know life. We know its secret flow. We have danced to its rhythms. We have loved it, not sentimentally through personal feelings, but pervasively, stretching ourselves from our hearts outwards so far, oh, so far,

Mulk Raj Anand

Writer 1905-2004

that life seemed to have no limits, that miracles seemed possible."

Anand was, of course, responding to the widely-held British belief that Indians were not only incapable of governing themselves but were also so hidebound and conservative as to be ill-equipped to deal with the problems and conditions of modernity. But he went farther, in his art and his thought, than simple polemics: the entirety of his work was committed to the idea that humanity in all of its manifestations was capable of the most profound changes and accomplishments.

Anand's novels lent voice to the voiceless—untouchables, peasants, women—and his criticism made the extraordinary history of Indian art accessible to countless people in new and exciting ways. He was not unique among the people of his



Courtesy: SAHITYA AKADEMI